Susanna B. Berkouwer

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Research fields

Primary: Environmental economics, development economics
Secondary: Behavioral economics, political economy

Academic appointments

University of Pennsylvania, The Wharton School
- Assistant Professor of Business Economics and Public Policy 2020–
- Robert J. Aresty, W'63 Faculty Scholar 2022–2025

National Bureau of Economic Research (NBER)
- Faculty Research Fellow, Development Economics Program 2023–
- Faculty Research Fellow, Environmental and Energy Economics Program 2023–

Affiliations

- Voting expert, Open Carbon Protocol 2026–
- Research Affiliate, International Growth Centre 2025–
- Associate Editor, *Journal of Environmental Economics and Management* 2024–
- Associate Editor, *Journal of Development Economics* 2023–
- Affiliate, Bureau for Research and Economic Analysis of Development (BREAD) 2023–
- Affiliate, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL) 2022–
- Fellow, The Coase Project 2022–

Education

- Ph.D., Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Berkeley 2014–2020
- M.A., International and Development Economics, Yale University 2012–2013
- B.Sc., Statistics (with Economics), University College London 2007–2010

Journal publications

Berkouwer, S., P. Biscaye, M. Mikdash, S. Puller, and C. Wolfram. "Voltage quality and economic activity." Accepted, *Journal of Political Economy: Microeconomics*.

Wolfram, C., E. Miguel, E. Hsu, and S. Berkouwer(r). "Contracting structures in public procurement: Evidence from donor-funded electrification in Kenya." Accepted, *Review of Economics and Statistics*.

Berkouwer, S., and J. Dean. 2026. "The cost-effectiveness of clean cookstove carbon mitigation after adjusting for additionality and impact." *Climate Change Economics*, 17(4)2650008.

Berkouwer, S., and J. Dean. 2026. "Cooking, health, and daily exposure to pollution spikes." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 18(2)511–47.

Berkouwer, S., P. Biscaye, E. Hsu, O. Kim, K. Lee, E. Miguel, and C. Wolfram. 2023. "Money or power? Choosing Covid-19 aid in Kenya." *Energy Economics*, 127(B)107036.

Berkouwer, S., and J. Dean. 2022. "Credit, attention, and externalities in the adoption of energy efficient technologies by low-income households." *American Economic Review*, 112(10)3291–3330.

Berkouwer, S., P. Biscaye, S. Puller, and C. Wolfram. 2022. "Disbursing emergency relief through utilities: Evidence from Ghana." *Journal of Development Economics*, 156(C)102826.

Berkouwer, S. 2020. “Electric heating and the effects of temperature on household electricity consumption in South Africa.” *Energy Journal*, 41(4)209–230.

Working papers

Wolfram, C., S. Berkouwer, F. Vial, E. Hsu, O. Kim, and E. Miguel®. “The distribution of power: Favoritism, efficiency, and equity in energy infrastructure.” *Revision requested*, *Journal of the European Economic Association*.

Azevedo, E., S. Berkouwer, A. van Benthem, P. Mishra, and A. Russo. “Integrity and unraveling in carbon offset markets.”

Berkouwer, S., and J. Dean. “Green subsidies with demand distortions.” *Submitted*.

Berkouwer, S., M. Bariya, P. Biscaye, M. Odero, N. Klugman, J. Adkins, and G. Flaspohler. “Distribution grid constraints on Africa’s energy transition: Customer-level evidence from high-frequency power-quality measurements.” *Submitted*.

Selected research in progress

“Morality, offsets, and the global cost of climate change mitigation” with J. Dean

“Watts for supper? The socioeconomic drivers and impacts of electric stove adoption in Kenya” with J. Dean

Other publications

Klugman, N., J. Adkins, S. Berkouwer, K. Abrokwah, M. Podolsky, P. Pannuto, C. Wolfram, J. Taneja, and P. Dutta. 2023. “Measuring Grid Reliability in Ghana.” in T. Madon et al. (Eds.), *Introduction to Development Engineering: A Framework with Applications from the Field*.

Klugman, N., J. Adkins, S. Berkouwer, K. Abrokwah, I. Bobashev, P. Pannuto, M. Podolsky, A. Suseno, R. Thatte, C. Wolfram, J. Taneja, and P. Dutta. 2019. “Hardware, Apps, and Surveys at Scale: Insights from Measuring Grid Reliability in Accra, Ghana.” *COMPASS’19*.

Berkouwer, S., A. Sultan, and S. Yehia. 2014. “Homosexuality in Sudan and Egypt: Stories of the Struggle for Survival.” *LGBTQ Policy Journal*, Vol. IV, pp. 66–76.

Teaching

Wharton

Environmental & Energy Economics and Policy (MBA elective: BEPP 7630)	Fall 2027
Environmental & Energy Economics and Policy (Undergraduate: BEPP 2630)	Fall 2027
Microeconomics (MBA Core: BEPP 6110)	Fall 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

UC Berkeley (Graduate Student Instructor)

Data and Decisions (MBA Core: MBA 200)	Fall 2017

Yale University (Teaching Fellow)

Economics of Poverty Alleviation (Undergraduate: ECON 327)	Spring 2013
Economics of Natural Resources (Undergraduate: ECON 330)	Fall 2012

External grants

Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics, 2025 ($76,000) with Joshua Dean
International Growth Centre–Uganda, 2024 ($125,000) with Joshua Dean
J-PAL Social Protection Initiative, 2023 ($7,500) with Joshua Dean
Millennium Challenge Corporation, 2021 ($1,550,000) with Duncan Callaway and Steven Puller
USAID Power Africa, 2021 ($55,000) with Edward Miguel
International Growth Centre–Sierra Leone, 2020 ($77,000) with Steven Puller and Catherine Wolfram

International Growth Centre–Kenya, 2020 ($25,000) with Eric Hsu, Oliver Kim, Kenneth Lee, Edward Miguel, Catherine Wolfram
Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries, 2020 ($46,500) with Eric Hsu, Kenneth Lee, Edward Miguel, Catherine Wolfram
DFID EEG, 2020 ($29,000) with Edward Miguel, Catherine Wolfram
International Growth Centre–Kenya, 2018 ($24,300) with Joshua Dean
Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics, 2018 ($31,544) with Joshua Dean
DFID EDI, 2018 ($361,000) with Edward Miguel, Catherine Wolfram

Awards & Scholarships

Wharton Teaching Excellence Award, 2025–26
Wharton Teaching Excellence Award, 2024–25
World Bank Public Institutions Conference, Best Paper in Regulations, 2025
AAEA, Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation, Honorable Mention, 2021
US/International Association for Energy Economics, Best Student Paper Award, 2019
Art Rosenfeld Award for Energy Efficiency, 2018
Prins Bernhard Cultuurfonds, 2014
Dr Hendrik Muller's Vaderlandsch Fonds, 2012

Seminar and conference presentations *(*scheduled)*

2027 *Bocconi Environmental Policy Symposium
2026 MIT/Harvard, NBER SI (DEV), Energy Camp at UC Berkeley, Columbia, UCSB, Penn State, Calgary, UPenn
2025 BII, London School of Economics, Princeton, Coase Conference at Chicago, World Bank, International Growth Centre–Uganda, Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries Conference, ETHOS Conference, IFPRI
2024 Michigan, UC San Diego, Michigan State, NBER (EEE), Coase Conference at Chicago, sustainable development conference at GW/UVA/WB, Energy Camp at UC Berkeley, environmental economics workshop at LSE/Imperial, World Bank, St. Andrews
2023 Yale, NEUDC at Harvard, IAP at USC, Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries at MIT, Energy Camp at UC Berkeley, Coase Conference at Chicago, EPIC Workshop at Chicago, NBER (EEE), University of Arizona, Inter-American Development Bank, Upenn
2022 Coase Conference at Chicago, Columbia, BREAD at UCL, Energy Camp at UC Berkeley, Occasional Workshop at UC Santa Barbara, Arizona State, CMU/Pittsburgh, Resources for the Future, Center for Global Development, Busara Center, Working Group on Kenyan Political Economy, Strathmore, UPenn
2021 Duke, Cornell, University of Hawai'i, Energy Camp at UC Berkeley, IDE Conference at Yale, London School of Economics, Berkeley-Harvard-Yale (EEE), World Bank, ASSA, AERE, GiveWell, PacDev, OSWEET, UPenn
2020 NBER Fall Meetings (DEV), NBER SI (EEE), CEGA E2A (Climate Change & Global Poverty), Early-Career Behavioral Economics, UPenn, Dartmouth, Boston University, Tufts, Sciences Po, University of British Columbia, Johns Hopkins (Carey), World Bank, Stockholm (IIES)
2019 WGAPE at the University of British Columbia, Occasional Workshop at UC Santa Barbara, Heartland Workshop at UI Urbana-Champaign, USAEE, University of Nevada, Reno, Paris School of Economics (EDI), UC Berkeley
Prior WGAPE at the University of British Columbia, IPWSD at Columbia, CREEC at Makerere University, Busara Center, UC Berkeley

Discussions

2022 NBER (EEE)
2019 NEUDC at Northwestern

Journal refereeing

AEJ: Applied Economics, AEJ: Economic Policy, American Economic Review, AER: Insights, Climatic Change, Economic Development and Cultural Change, Economic Journal, Economics Letters, Energy Journal, Energy Economics, Environment and Development Economics, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Development Economics (pre-results review), Journal of Health Economics, Journal of Human Resources, Journal of Political Economy, Journal of Political Economy: Microeconomics, Journal of Public Economics, Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists, Journal of the European Economic Association, Management Science, Nature Climate Change, Quarterly Journal of Economics, Review of Economics and Statistics, Review of Economic Studies, Utilities Policy, World Bank Economic Review

Grant & conference reviewing

Penn Global, NSF Economics Program, J-PAL King Climate Action Initiative, Alfred P. Sloan Foundation, Fund for Innovation in Development, Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries

Other writing

12. Cookstove subsidies fight climate change at a lower cost, *Knowledge at Wharton*, Sep. 2026
11. Subsidise the stove, not the electricity: market distortions and clean-cooking subsidies in sub-Saharan Africa, *International Growth Centre Policy Brief*, June 2026
10. Will high-efficiency cookstoves save lives? *Chicago Booth Review*, Sep. 2024
9. Strengthening the electricity grid in Ghana, *MCC Evaluation Brief*, Mar. 2024
8. The health impacts of average vs peak pollution exposure: Evidence from cooking in Kenya, *VoxDev*, Feb. 2024
7. The overlooked causes of air pollution, *Knowledge at Wharton*, Feb. 2024
6. Private actions in the presence of externalities: The health impacts of reducing air pollution peaks but not ambient exposure, *Becker Friedman Institute Research Brief*, Oct. 2023
5. Money or Power? Financial infrastructure and optimal policy, *Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries*, Apr. 2022
4. How to drive energy efficiency in low-income countries, *Knowledge at Wharton*, Nov. 2021
3. Could easier credit speed the adoption of energy efficiency? *Chicago Booth Review*, Sep. 2020
2. Can energy efficiency subsidies improve welfare in low-income countries? Evidence from Kenya says yes, *VoxDev*, May 2020
1. How do credit and psychology affect the adoption of profitable energy efficient technologies in Kenya? *International Growth Centre Policy Brief*, Aug. 2019

Media coverage

6. How much does clean cooking reduce emissions? *Resources Radio*, Oct. 2026
5. Cooking, health, and daily exposure to pollution, *The Backstory Podcast*, Aug. 2024
4. Cookstoves reduce charcoal use by 40%, *The Carbon Herald*, Feb. 2024
3. Climate Crisis: Who does climate change hit the hardest? *The Ripple Effect Podcast*, Apr. 2023
2. Measuring reliability with GridWatch, *Energy for Growth Hub Coffee Break Briefing*, Dec. 2021
1. Wharton study finds energy-efficient technologies can help families save money, *The Daily Pennsylvanian*, Dec. 2021

Conference organizing

2022 Organizer, Penn Development Conference on Climate Change & Environment

Professional service

2024 *Panelist*, AERE: Cutting edge research in environmental and resource economics
2023 *Lecturer*, UC Berkeley Summer School in Environmental and Energy Economics
2023 *Mentor*, American Economic Association Committee on the Status of LGBTQ+ Individuals in the Economics Profession (AEA CSQIEP)
2022 *Panelist*, AERE: Developing and managing a research agenda
2021 *Judge*, US Association for Energy Economics: Best Student Paper Award
2021 *Faculty coach*, Researcher matching programme, International Growth Centre
2021 *Panelist*, Economists for Equity at Berkeley: Womxn's Faculty and Alumni panel
2020 *Panelist*, American Economic Association: LGBTQ Job Market panel
2017–2019 *Leadership board*, Women in Economics at Berkeley
2013–2014 *Member of the editorial board*, *Harvard LGBTQ Policy Journal*

PhD Advising *(with graduation year and initial placement)*

Martín Navarrete, *PhD Second-year paper advisor*
Peter Lugthart, *PhD Committee member*
Prakash Mishra, *PhD Committee member* (2025): Post-doc at Dartmouth, Faculty at Caltech

Other positions

2014–2020 UC Berkeley – *Graduate Student Researcher*
2013–2014 Harvard University, Kennedy School of Government – *EPoD Research Fellow*
2010–2012 Citibank – *Analyst*

Languages

English (native), Dutch (native), French (advanced), Spanish (advanced), Swahili (conversant)

Citizenship

Netherlands (U.S. Permanent Resident)

October 17, 2026